

L.K. ADVANI
80, LEADER OF THE OPPOSITION (NEW)

THE PHOENIX

BECAUSE he is NDA's prime ministerial candidate. Because he managed the most successful comeback in BJP less than two years after he was forced to resign as party chief over his controversial comments. Because despite not withdrawing his Jinnah comments, he was chosen by RSS to lead BJP back to power. Because he is the one who shapes and leads the Opposition's attack both in Parliament and outside.

BIG PASSION:

Is a tech buff who updates himself on the latest gadgets even if that meant a trip to Seattle in 1990.

FOOD QUIRK:

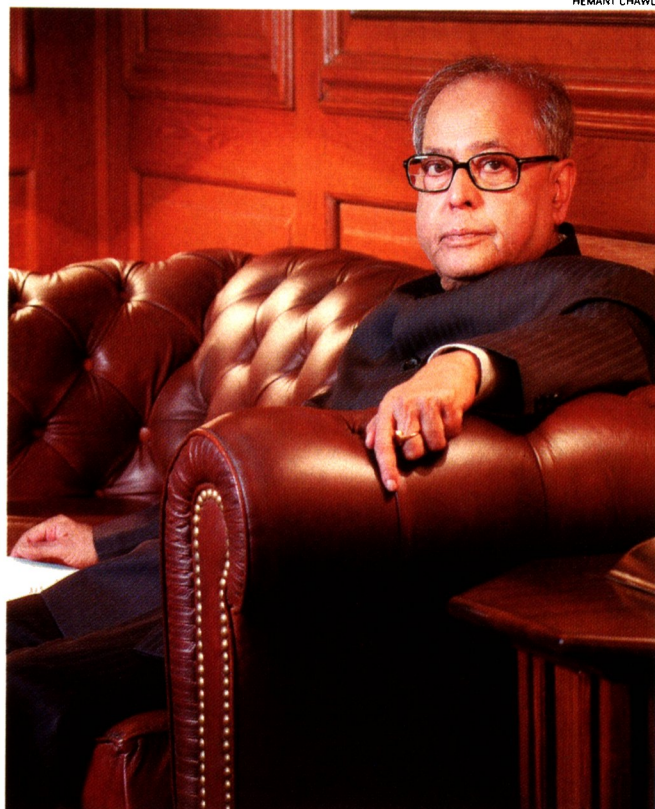
A frugal eater, but can't say no to hot milk with cardamom.

TIME OFF:

Bollywood films and old English war movies like *Bridge On The River Kwai* and *Sink The Bismarck!*.

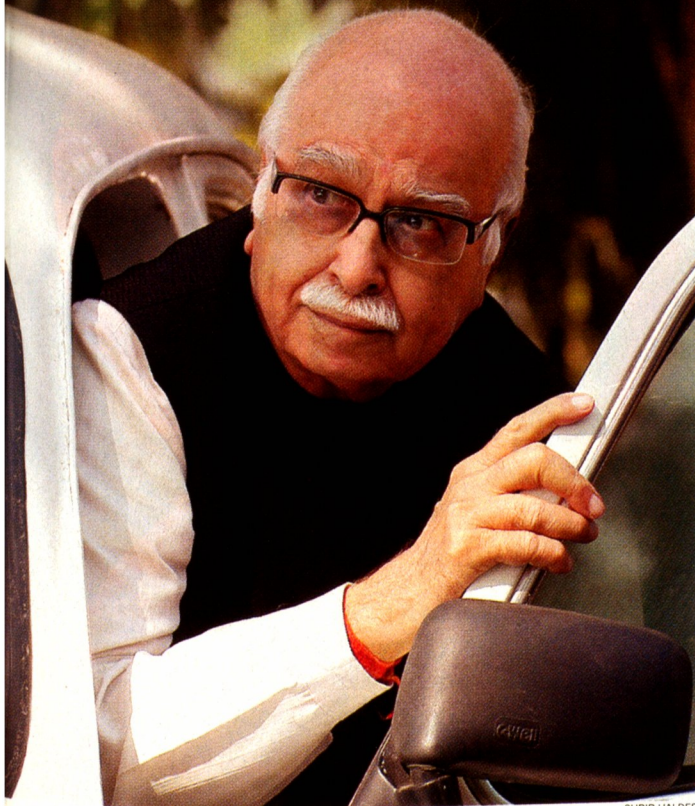
JUST READ:

Will Durant's *The Case For India* and Thomas Friedman's *The World Is Flat*.



HEMANT CHAWLA

HIS BIRTHDAY WAS A SHOW OF STRENGTH, WITH RSS, BJP AND NDA LEADERS IN ATTENDANCE.



SHIRIR HALDER

PRANAB MUKERJEE
72, EXTERNAL AFFAIRS MINISTER (8)

THE MEDIUM

BECAUSE both Sonia Gandhi and Manmohan Singh count on him to coordinate with UPA allies on the Indo-US nuclear deal. Because he has presided over GOMS on issues like airport modernisation and the Right to Information. Because when there is a knock on Room No.13 in Parliament, it is usually a Cabinet minister, a Left ally or an Opposition leader seeking his advice.

THE BIG LOSS: Not becoming President. He was the Left's candidate but the Congress said he was "indispensable" to the Cabinet.

CONSOLATION PRIZE: Padma Vibhushan

CURRENTLY READING: *India After*

Gandhi by Ramachandra Guha, a present from his daughter Sharmishta.

LOVES TO: Read Victorian poetry.

STRANGE BUT TRUE: His favourite movie is *Benji*, a children's film about a lovable dog who solves problems.

HE HAS PRESIDED OVER 55 GOMS ON THE TRICKIEST ISSUES AND COMPLETED WORK ON 35.